Proposal for an After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program in Ontario Schools

Executive Summary

Proposal Overview: This document proposes the creation of an **After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program** for publicly funded elementary and secondary schools across Ontario. The program's goal is to **provide targeted academic tutoring in literacy and math** for students who are underperforming or have fallen behind, coupled with a mentorship component to support students' engagement and well-being. This initiative responds to widened learning gaps caused by the COVID-19 pandemic and longstanding educational inequities affecting students from marginalized or low-income backgrounds. By offering free, high-quality tutoring in small groups or one-on-one settings after school, along with positive role-model mentorship, the program aims to accelerate learning recovery and promote equitable outcomes.

Need and Rationale: Ontario's students experienced significant learning disruptions during the pandemic, leading to measurable declines in achievement – for example, recent assessments show **fewer students meeting provincial standards in reading and writing, and only about half of Grade 6 and 9 students meeting the math standard**[1]. These disruptions have hit vulnerable groups hardest: in 2020–21 the gap in Grade 9 credit completion between First Nations students and the provincial average widened to 31 percentage points[2], and educators report that students in rural and Northern communities often lack access to after-school help due to issues like transportation[3]. Many families, especially in low-income areas, cannot afford private tutoring, putting their children at further disadvantage. Research has consistently shown that **"high-dosage" tutoring is one of the most effective interventions** for catching up students academically[4]. Moreover, mentorship programs have a proven record of improving student outcomes – for instance, Ontario's *Pathways to Education* program, which provides tutoring and mentoring to at-risk youth, significantly boosted high school graduation rates in several low-income communities (e.g. from 44% to 82%

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[1] https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/toronto/eqao-results-2023-1.7335283

[2] https://education.chiefs-of-ontario.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/SystemicGapsProject_StudentOutcomes-1.pdf

[3] https://peopleforeducation.ca/our-work/inequities-persist/

[4] https://nssa.stanford.edu/news/high-impact-tutoring-some-research-based-essentials

in one Toronto neighborhood)[5] [6]. These facts underscore an urgent need and opportunity for an Ontario-wide after-school tutoring and mentorship initiative.

Program Plan: The proposed program will be implemented via Ontario's school boards in partnership with community organizations. **Qualified tutors** – including certified teachers (active or retired), teacher candidates, and vetted community tutors – will provide **personalized instruction in reading, writing, mathematics, science, and other core subjects**. Tutoring will occur in small groups (3–5 students) or one-on-one, for **at least 2–3 sessions per week** per student, focusing on the areas of greatest need. Simultaneously, each participating student will be matched with a **mentor** (such as a trained older student, community role model, or professional volunteer) who can offer guidance, encouragement, and homework help outside regular class time. The program will prioritize schools and students most in need – based on academic performance indicators and socio-economic data – to ensure equity.

Expected Benefits: By extending learning support beyond school hours, the program is expected to: (1) **Improve students' literacy and numeracy skills** (as measured by higher classroom grades and EQAO standardized test scores) among those below provincial standards; (2) **Increase student confidence, engagement, and attendance** by providing personalized support and positive role models; and (3) **Narrow achievement gaps** linked to socio-economic status, race, or geography, contributing to higher overall graduation rates and more equitable outcomes across Ontario[7]. Over time, these improvements will strengthen Ontario's education system and workforce, yielding long-term social and economic benefits that outweigh the program's costs.

Alignment with Provincial Priorities: The After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program aligns with the Ontario Ministry of Education's core commitments to boost foundational skills and support every student. It builds upon the **Ontario Learning Recovery Action Plan (2022)** – which invested $175 million in temporary tutoring

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[5] https://www.canada.ca/content/dam/esdc-edsc/documents/corporate/reports/evaluations/pathways-education-report/summary-of-evaluation-of-the-pathways-to-education-en.pdf

[6] https://www.canada.ca/content/dam/esdc-edsc/documents/corporate/reports/evaluations/pathways-education-report/summary-of-evaluation-of-the-pathways-to-education-en.pdf

[7] https://education.chiefs-of-ontario.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/SystemicGapsProject_StudentOutcomes-1.pdf

supports to help students recover from pandemic-related learning loss[8] – by providing a permanent, sustainable framework for ongoing tutoring after school. It also complements existing initiatives such as the **Focus on Youth program and the Graduation Coach Program for Black Students**, which provide mentorship and targeted support to marginalized youth[9]. By directly addressing learning recovery, equity, and student well-being, this proposal supports the Ministry's vision of a "**world-class education system that focuses on foundational skills like reading, writing and math, while developing programs that eliminate barriers to success and ensure equitable outcomes for all students**"[10] [11].

The following sections detail the program's background, objectives, design, target population, budget, evaluation strategy, and its alignment with Ontario's education priorities.

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1. Background and Rationale

Learning Gaps from the Pandemic and Other Challenges

Ontario's students have endured unprecedented disruptions due to the COVID-19 pandemic and related school closures. Over two years of intermittent remote learning and reduced in-person instruction time have led to **significant learning loss**, particularly in literacy and mathematics. Standardized test results illustrate this impact: by the 2023–24 school year, **fewer Grade 3 and Grade 6 students met provincial standards in reading and writing compared to pre-pandemic cohorts, and math scores, while stabilizing, remain disappointingly low**[12]. For example, only **about 50% of Grade 6 students met the provincial math standard in 2023** (unchanged from the prior year and below historical norms), and the share of Grade 3 students meeting the reading standard actually fell by 2 percentage points from the

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[8] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

[9] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

[10] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[11] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[12] https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/toronto/eqao-results-2023-1.7335283

previous year[13]. These trends confirm that many students have *fallen behind in essential skills*. Without intervention, such early gaps in literacy and numeracy can have lasting effects on students' academic trajectories and future opportunities.

Beyond the averages, the pandemic **exacerbated pre-existing inequities** in education outcomes. Students from marginalized, low-income, rural, and Indigenous communities have been disproportionately affected. Many had fewer supports during remote learning due to factors like limited internet access, parents working essential jobs, or lack of affordable tutoring. Data from the Ontario Ministry of Education and stakeholders highlights the scope of these disparities:

- **Widening Achievement Gaps:** Even before COVID-19, students facing socio-economic challenges and other barriers scored lower on standardized tests. During the pandemic, these gaps widened. For instance, among First Nations students in provincially funded schools, the proportion "on track" to graduate (having 8 credits by end of Grade 9) was 19–21 percentage points lower than the provincial average pre-pandemic; this gap **ballooned to 31 points in 2020–21** during COVID disruptions[14]. Such statistics align with international evidence that students with pre-existing vulnerabilities (poverty, racial marginalization, special education needs, etc.) suffered greater learning losses due to pandemic-related school closures[15]. This underlines a critical need for targeted academic support to help these students catch up.
- **Regional and Socio-Economic Inequities:** Students in Northern Ontario and rural areas often have less access to academic enrichment outside school. A 2023 survey of Ontario principals found that only **29% of rural schools could offer certain extracurricular clubs (vs 40% in urban schools)**, largely due to factors like transportation barriers after school[16]. A secondary principal in Northern Ontario noted that *"after-school transportation is not available and limits after-school activities"* for students spread across distant communities[17]. Additionally, schools in lower-income neighborhoods tend to have fewer resources (e.g. they raise significantly less fundraising money than schools in

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[13] https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/toronto/eqao-results-2023-1.7335283

[14] https://education.chiefs-of-ontario.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/SystemicGapsProject_StudentOutcomes-1.pdf

[15] https://education.chiefs-of-ontario.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/SystemicGapsProject_StudentOutcomes-1.pdf

[16] https://peopleforeducation.ca/our-work/inequities-persist/

[17] https://peopleforeducation.ca/our-work/inequities-persist/

affluent areas, limiting the supports they can provide)[18]. These circumstances mean that the very students who could most benefit from extra tutoring and mentoring often have the **fewest opportunities to receive it**.

- **Limited Access to Affordable Tutoring:** Private tutoring in Ontario can be prohibitively expensive for many families, with costs that can exceed $40–$60 per hour per child. In recognition of this, the provincial government offered direct **"Catch Up" payments (one-time $200–$250 per child)** in 2022 to help parents purchase tutoring or learning supplies. While helpful, these short-term subsidies did not establish a long-term solution within the school system, and many families still lack reliable access to qualified tutoring support. A publicly funded after-school program would bridge this gap and **ensure that a student's learning recovery isn't contingent on their family's income**.
- **Impact on Student Well-Being and Engagement:** Learning setbacks have also affected student morale, mental health, and engagement with school. Educators report that students who fell behind academically often show lower confidence, higher absenteeism, and greater risk of disengaging from school. In extreme cases, prolonged academic struggles can contribute to increased dropout rates. Ontario's five-year high school graduation rate stands around 89% for all students, but only **60% for First Nations students**[19] – a stark indicator of inequitable outcomes. Providing early and ongoing academic support through tutoring, along with mentorship to encourage and guide students, can help address these issues. By intervening after school in a supportive environment, the program can rekindle students' interest in learning and prevent vulnerable youth from falling through the cracks.

Evidence for Tutoring and Mentoring Effectiveness

This proposal is built on strong evidence that supplementary tutoring and mentoring are effective strategies for improving student performance and reducing achievement gaps:

- **Proven Academic Gains from Tutoring:** Education research consistently finds that **frequent, small-group tutoring ("high-dosage" tutoring) is one of the most effective interventions** for accelerating student learning[20]. Tutoring programs implemented in other jurisdictions (and in Ontario on a limited basis) have yielded significant improvements in reading and math outcomes, often

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[18] https://peopleforeducation.ca/our-work/inequities-persist/

[19] https://education.chiefs-of-ontario.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/SystemicGapsProject_StudentOutcomes-1.pdf

[20] https://nssa.stanford.edu/news/high-impact-tutoring-some-research-based-essentials

equating to several months of additional learning gain over a school year. The effects are strongest for students who start below grade-level – precisely the target group for this program. Ontario's own recent experience confirms this: In spring 2022, the Ministry of Education launched a **Learning Recovery Tutoring program** (a temporary COVID-response measure) investing $175 million to provide free, small-group tutoring after school, during school, on weekends, and over the summer[21]. Over **200,000 students** took advantage of these tutoring supports in 2022–23, receiving an average of 23 hours of tutoring each, and many showed marked improvements – one school board reported a 96% success rate in previously struggling students achieving their Grade 9 math credit after receiving intensive tutoring[22]. This proposal builds on that success by making tutoring support a permanent feature of Ontario's education system.

- **Power of Mentorship:** Academic mentoring and coaching programs provide motivational and social-emotional benefits that complement tutoring. Positive relationships with mentors can increase students' resilience, career aspirations, and sense of belonging in school. Ontario has piloted mentorship-driven initiatives for specific populations with promising results. For example, the **Graduation Coach Program for Black Students** places dedicated mentors ("Graduation Coaches") in schools to support Black youth; this program has helped create more inclusive school environments and has shown success in improving Black students' credit accumulation and well-being[23]. Another example is the longstanding community-based **Pathways to Education** program, which, through tutoring, mentoring and wraparound support, has **dramatically increased high school graduation rates** in several low-income communities (e.g. Toronto's Regent Park saw graduation rates climb from 46%

[21] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

[22] https://www.principals.ca/en/opc-resources/tutoring-supports-program-extension.aspx

[23] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

pre-Pathways to 73% with the program[24] [25]). These successes demonstrate that adding mentorship to academic support not only helps academically but also bolsters students' confidence, attendance, and goal-setting – all of which are critical to long-term success.

- **Alignment with Community and Recovery Efforts:** There is broad consensus that learning recovery and equity must be top priorities. The Ontario Human Rights Commission's 2022 *Right to Read* inquiry highlighted that too many students struggle with reading proficiency and called for better supports. Organizations like People for Education have recommended that the province invest in **equitable out-of-school learning opportunities** so all students can benefit from enrichment, not just those in well-resourced communities[26] [27]. This proposed program heeds those calls. It also leverages community resources: many Ontario communities already have components to build on, such as local non-profits, volunteers, or partnerships (e.g., local colleges, universities, businesses, and service clubs) eager to help students through tutoring and mentorship. By coordinating these efforts under a provincial framework and providing funding and standards, Ontario can ensure **consistent, high-quality support** reaches the students who need it most.

In sum, the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program is grounded in a clear problem (learning gaps and inequities), addresses it with evidence-based strategies (tutoring and mentoring), and builds upon both government priorities and successful models. The next sections detail the program's intended objectives and how it will be implemented.

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2. Program Objectives

The After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program seeks to achieve the following core objectives, in alignment with Ontario's education priorities:

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[24] https://www.canada.ca/content/dam/esdc-edsc/documents/corporate/reports/evaluations/pathways-education-report/summary-of-evaluation-of-the-pathways-to-education-en.pdf

[25] https://www.canada.ca/content/dam/esdc-edsc/documents/corporate/reports/evaluations/pathways-education-report/summary-of-evaluation-of-the-pathways-to-education-en.pdf

[26] https://peopleforeducation.ca/our-work/inequities-persist/

[27] https://peopleforeducation.ca/our-work/inequities-persist/

1. **Boost Literacy and Numeracy Achievement: Improve students' proficiency in reading, writing, and mathematics**, especially for those currently performing below the provincial standards. The goal is to help participating students reach or exceed grade-level expectations in core skills by providing targeted academic interventions. Success will be measured through improvements in report card grades and standardized test results (e.g., EQAO assessments) for those students.
2. **Enhance Student Engagement and Confidence: Increase students' confidence, motivation, and engagement in school** by providing supportive one-on-one and small-group learning experiences. Through regular tutoring and mentorship, students will build skills, overcome learning obstacles, and gain confidence in their abilities. Improved attendance records, higher class participation, and positive feedback from students and parents will serve as indicators of progress.
3. **Promote Equity and Reduce Achievement Gaps: Narrow the achievement gaps** associated with socio-economic status, race, Indigenous identity, disability, English/French language learner status, and geographic location. The program will prioritize high-need communities to ensure that students who lack access to extra help (such as those from low-income families or remote areas) receive quality support. Over time, the expectation is for more equitable outcomes – e.g., raising the performance of lower-achieving groups closer to the provincial average, and improving high school credit accumulation and graduation rates in historically underperforming student populations[28].
4. **Provide Mentorship and Positive Role Models: Connect students with mentors** who can guide them academically and personally, fostering positive relationships and life skills. By pairing each student with a consistent mentor (older students or community volunteers), the program aims to improve students' resilience, goal-setting, and sense of belonging at school. Outcomes will include qualitative feedback on student well-being (surveys on self-esteem, aspirations, etc.) and tracking of behavioural indicators (such as reduced disciplinary incidents and higher rates of staying in school).

These objectives will be refined into specific performance targets (see Section 6: Evaluation and Metrics for Success) to ensure accountability. The ultimate vision is a program that not only raises test scores, but also holistically supports students in their academic journey, contributing to a more just and high-achieving education system.

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[28] https://education.chiefs-of-ontario.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/SystemicGapsProject_StudentOutcomes-1.pdf

3. Program Design and Implementation Plan

Program Structure

The After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program will operate as a **province-wide initiative delivered at the local level by school boards** and schools, with oversight and support from the Ministry of Education. Key design features of the program include:

- **Targeted School Selection:** The program will initially be implemented in **public elementary and secondary schools identified as high-need** – as indicated by metrics such as below-average EQAO scores in reading or math, low graduation rates, or a high proportion of students from low-income or marginalized communities. This targeting ensures resources are directed where the academic gaps are greatest. The Ministry will collaborate with school boards to develop a needs-based selection index (leveraging data like EQAO results, census-based socio-economic indicators, and consultation with boards) to determine which schools or regions receive the program first.
- **Qualified Tutoring Staff:** Each participating school will receive funding to hire or contract a team of **qualified tutors** to conduct the after-school sessions. Tutors could be:
    - *Certified teachers* (including current teachers interested in overtime hours or recently retired teachers looking to contribute part-time).
    - *Education students or recent graduates* (e.g., Bachelor of Education candidates, early-career teachers seeking experience).
    - *Skilled community tutors* (individuals with relevant expertise, such as former educators or professionals in math/science/literacy fields, vetted by the school board).

    Tutors will undergo a selection process to ensure they have the content knowledge and communication skills to effectively teach the intended subjects. The program will maintain a low student-to-tutor ratio (generally **no more than 5 students per tutor, and ideally 1–3 students per tutor for key literacy/numeracy interventions**), reflecting research that very small group or one-on-one settings yield the best results[29].
- **Mentorship Component:** A unique aspect of this program is the integration of a mentorship model alongside academic tutoring. Each student enrolled in the program will be matched with a **dedicated mentor**. Mentors may be:

[29] https://nssa.stanford.edu/news/high-impact-tutoring-some-research-based-essentials

- *Older students (peer mentors)* – for example, responsible high school seniors mentoring elementary students, or university/college students mentoring high school participants.
- *Community volunteers* – such as local professionals, members of community organizations, or retirees willing to support youth.
- *Existing mentorship programs* – The program can partner with established mentorship initiatives (like Big Brothers Big Sisters or the Ontario Mentoring Coalition) to recruit and train volunteers.

  Mentors will commit to regularly meeting with their assigned student (e.g. weekly or biweekly) during the after-school program hours. Their role is to **provide encouragement, help students set goals, assist with homework or study skills, and serve as positive role models**. The mentorship is meant to complement academic tutoring by addressing non-academic barriers to learning – such as lack of motivation, low self-esteem, or absence of career guidance – that often affect struggling students.

- **Curriculum and Materials:** The tutoring sessions will focus on **foundational subjects – primarily literacy and math**, as well as other core areas (science and other subjects) where students need support. The Ministry, in collaboration with curriculum experts and school boards, will develop or provide curated **tutoring materials aligned with Ontario's curriculum**. This could include reading intervention programs and math skill-building resources that are evidence-based (for example, guided reading programs, numeracy skill practice software, and homework toolkits). By aligning tutoring content with the Ontario curriculum and educators' classroom strategies, the program ensures that after-school instruction directly reinforces what students need to learn in class. Additionally, age-appropriate resources will be provided to facilitate mentorship activities (such as goal-setting worksheets, career exploration resources, and social-emotional learning activities for mentors to use in sessions).
- **Operational Schedule:** Tutoring and mentorship sessions will be held **after regular school hours**, likely for about **1–2 hours per day, 2–4 days per week** at each participating school (exact days to be determined based on local needs and logistics). Sessions might run, for example, from 3:30–5:30 PM. Each tutor can work with multiple small groups in rotation (e.g., two 45-minute sessions in an afternoon). The schedule will also incorporate a break for a healthy snack or recreation, which can help students recharge and build informal mentor-mentee relationships. To maximize accessibility, schools will coordinate late bus service or transportation support where possible, especially in rural areas (working with school transportation consortia or community transit solutions) – this addresses

the critical barrier of after-school transportation in many regions[30]. For remote or very small schools where in-person tutoring staff may be limited, **online tutoring** options can be offered (building on resources like TVO's Mathify and Eurêka! online tutoring services already used in Ontario[31]). The program's design is meant to be flexible to local context: urban schools might host daily on-site tutoring hubs, whereas rural communities might use a mix of in-person and virtual tutoring to reach students in outlying areas.

- **Mentor-Tutor Coordination:** Each school's program will have a **Program Coordinator (likely a teacher or staff member)** who manages logistics, including pairing students with tutors and mentors, scheduling sessions, tracking attendance and progress, and liaising with parents. The coordinator will ensure that tutors and mentors work hand-in-hand – for example, a mentor might sit in on a tutoring session at times to better understand the student's academic challenges, or a tutor might communicate with the mentor about skills the student should practice between sessions. This cohesive approach ensures that academic instruction and mentorship are reinforcing each other. Training sessions (see below) will emphasize how tutors and mentors can collaborate to support student growth holistically.
- **Community and Parental Engagement:** The program encourages involvement of the broader community and parents. School councils and local community organizations will be invited to support program delivery – for instance, **local businesses or charities might contribute snacks, books, or funds for supplies**, and non-profits or post-secondary institutions might help recruit volunteers. Parents will receive regular updates on their child's progress and be offered resources (e.g., tips to support reading at home) so they can complement the program's efforts. This community-based approach not only stretches resources but also fosters a **network of support around each student**, reinforcing the importance of education.

Implementation Phases and Timeline

To ensure effective rollout, the program will be phased in over time:

- **Phase 1 – Planning and Pilot (Year 1):** In the initial year after approval (e.g. 2026–27 school year), the Ministry of Education will assemble a provincial **Program Task Force** including representatives from the Ministry, school boards, principals, teachers, and community partners. This task force will finalize

[30] https://peopleforeducation.ca/our-work/inequities-persist/

[31] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

program guidelines, develop standard training for tutors and mentors, and create processes for selecting target schools and students. A pilot implementation will launch in a **representative sample of school boards** (for example, 2–3 boards in urban, suburban, rural, and Northern settings) to test program logistics on a smaller scale. Approximately 50–100 schools could be included in this pilot phase. Data from Phase 1 (on student participation, academic progress, feedback from tutors/mentors) will be used to refine the model.

- **Phase 2 – Expansion (Years 2–3):** Following a successful pilot, the program will be expanded to more schools and boards across the province in years 2 and 3. The targeting criteria will be applied to identify additional high-need schools that should receive the program. By the end of Year 3, the goal is to have the program operating in **all school boards across Ontario**, encompassing **several hundred schools** and thousands of students. The phased approach allows for adjustments based on lessons learned and ensures that infrastructure (recruiting enough tutors, setting up transportation, etc.) can scale up effectively.
- **Phase 3 – Full Provincial Rollout (Year 4 and beyond):** After initial scaling, the program should become a permanent, ongoing offering at all identified high-need schools, with potential to expand to any school where significant numbers of students require academic support. As learning gaps are addressed and overall student achievement improves, the criteria for participation can be adjusted. The program could eventually be made available as a *preventative* support in any school where teachers or parents see a need, not just those in crisis. Long-term sustainability will involve incorporating the program's funding into the core education budget (e.g., through the Grants for Student Needs or its successor funding formula) to ensure stability.

Tutor and Mentor Training

A critical component of program implementation is **training**. The Ministry will develop standardized training modules for both tutors and mentors to ensure quality and consistency province-wide:

- **Tutor Training:** Tutors will be trained in effective remedial instructional techniques aligned with Ontario's curriculum and the latest evidence on learning recovery. This includes strategies for teaching literacy (such as phonics-based reading interventions for elementary students, as recommended by Ontario's recent **Right to Read** report) and mathematics (such as using manipulatives and real-life problem-solving to build foundational numeracy). Tutors will also be briefed on differentiating instruction for diverse learning needs – for example, techniques to support English Language Learners or

students with learning disabilities. Training will cover how to create a safe, supportive small-group learning environment and how to monitor and report on student progress. Ongoing professional development opportunities (perhaps in partnership with Faculties of Education or Ontario's coaching networks) will be offered so tutors can continuously improve their practice.

- **Mentor Training:** While mentors are not expected to be instructors, they will receive orientation on topics such as mentorship best practices, communication with youth, cultural competency, anti-bullying and mental health first aid basics. Mentors will learn how to build trust with their mentees, encourage positive study habits, and recognize when a student may need additional help (academic or personal). Given that some mentors will be older students, their training will also include guidance on setting boundaries and seeking support from program staff if any serious issues arise. The Ontario Mentoring Coalition and established mentorship organizations could assist in developing these training materials, leveraging their expertise in youth mentoring. Both tutors and mentors will be required to undergo background checks and adhere to school board volunteer policies to ensure student safety.

Partnerships and Governance

The program will rely on a collaborative approach between the Ministry of Education, local school boards, and community partners:

- **Ministry of Education:** The Ministry will provide overall **policy direction, funding, and evaluation** frameworks for the program. It will also facilitate coordination between different provincial initiatives (for example, ensuring this program complements the Ministry's in-school **Literacy and Math Strategy** and mental health supports). The Ministry may consider using a portion of its **Responsive Education Partnerships (formerly PPF)** funding to support this program, signaling it as a high-impact initiative for learning recovery. Additionally, the Ministry should explore inter-ministerial collaboration – e.g., with the Ministry of Health (on student mental health aspects) or the Ministry of Children, Community and Social Services – to strengthen the mentorship component and address any non-academic barriers students face.
- **School Boards and Schools:** District school boards will be the primary implementers, responsible for **hiring staff, selecting participating schools, and overseeing program delivery** in their region according to the provincial guidelines. Individual schools will host and advertise the after-school sessions, identify eligible students (through teacher referrals and assessment data), and communicate with parents. Each participating school will have the aforementioned Program Coordinator (could be an existing staff member given a stipend or a newly hired coordinator for larger programs) who manages day-to-

day operations. School boards will be expected to report data and outcomes back to the Ministry for accountability and evaluation purposes.

- **Community and Volunteer Partners:** The program will actively seek partnerships to enhance its reach and sustainability. Potential collaborators include:
    - **Non-Profit Organizations:** Groups with experience in tutoring or mentorship (e.g., Frontier College for literacy programs, Big Brothers Big Sisters for mentorship, or local settlement agencies to support newcomer students) can help recruit and manage volunteers, provide training, or even run program sites in high-need areas beyond school property.
    - **Post-Secondary Institutions:** Universities and colleges (especially those with Faculties of Education or Social Work) can be tapped to provide tutors/mentors (students gaining practicum hours or volunteering) and to assist with program evaluation (faculty-led research on program outcomes).
    - **Corporate Sponsors and Foundations:** Businesses could contribute funds or in-kind resources (such as equipment, software, books, or meal programs). For example, a corporation might sponsor the purchase of laptops or tablets for an e-learning lab, or a local grocery chain might donate healthy snacks for participating students. Corporate volunteer programs might also encourage employees to volunteer as mentors. While the **core funding will come from the government (to ensure stability and equity)**, these community contributions will enrich the program and reduce pressure on public funds.
    - **Municipalities and Libraries:** In some communities, especially where school facilities or transportation options are limited, municipal recreation centers or public libraries could host tutoring sessions. This would require coordination at the local level but could extend the program's reach, particularly in underserviced areas.

By establishing a broad network of partnerships, the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program will become a community-driven effort, reflecting local needs while supported by provincial resources. This collaborative implementation is key to the program's success and sustainability.

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4. Target Population and Equity Considerations

The proposed program is deliberately designed with **equity and inclusivity** at its core, targeting students most likely to benefit from additional support and ensuring no

student is left behind due to personal or socio-economic circumstances. Key considerations for target population and equity include:

Target Population

- **Academically Struggling Students:** The primary beneficiaries will be students who are **performing below provincial standards in literacy and math** or otherwise identified as struggling academically. This includes students who: score below the provincial standard (Level 3) on EQAO assessments; receive below-average or failing grades in English, Math, or other core subjects; or have been identified by classroom teachers as needing remedial support. Both elementary and secondary students are eligible – from early readers who need help with phonics, to middle-schoolers falling behind in math, to high school students at risk of not earning required credits. By addressing learning challenges early and consistently, the program can prevent small gaps from widening over time.
- **Students from Low-Income and Marginalized Backgrounds:** Within the above academic criteria, **priority will be given to students from underserved groups**, such as those from low-income families, racialized communities, Indigenous (First Nations, Métis, and Inuit) students, newcomers (English/French language learners), and students with special education needs. These groups often face additional barriers – from lack of access to private tutoring, to fewer educational resources at home, to experiences of discrimination – which the program seeks to counteract. For instance, if a school has more interested students than available tutor capacity, a weighting or referral system will ensure that those with the greatest need (academic and socio-economic) are served first. *No student will be turned away for inability to pay*, as the program is publicly funded or subsidized.
- **Grade and Age Ranges:** The program will serve **students in Kindergarten to Grade 12**, with programming tailored to different age groups:
    - In the **elementary grades (K–8)**, the emphasis will be on building strong foundations in reading, writing, and arithmetic. Early intervention is crucial; thus, even primary-grade students who show signs of reading difficulties (such as those identified through new screening measures in Year 2 of Kindergarten to Grade 2[32]) can receive tutoring to ensure they don't fall behind. Junior and intermediate students (Grades 4–8) struggling in literacy or math will get help to master key concepts and prepare for the transition to high school.

[32] https://efis.fma.csc.gov.on.ca/faab/Memos/B2023/B03_EN.pdf

    - In **secondary school (Grades 9–12)**, tutoring will focus on helping students meet the requirements for credit accumulation and graduation, particularly in compulsory courses like English and math. Grade 9 and 10 students could receive help in the new de-streamed curriculum, which some may find challenging without the prior applied/academic streaming[33]. Senior students could receive tutoring and mentoring that also supports their post-secondary pathway planning (for example, tutoring in Grade 11 math or science courses that are prerequisites for college or university programs).
- **Geographical Coverage and Rural Considerations:** The program is province-wide, including all regions of Ontario – urban, suburban, rural, and remote. Special attention will be paid to **Northern Ontario and rural communities**, where schools are farther apart and students may have less access to after-school services. As noted, transportation solutions or virtual tutoring options will be provided to ensure rural students can participate. The program also aims to serve schools in inner-city or high-poverty neighborhoods of urban areas (which often concentrate disadvantaged students). By spanning the province, the program acknowledges that learning gaps and the need for mentorship exist in communities from large cities to small towns, albeit with different local challenges.

Equity and Inclusion Strategies

To truly advance equity, the program design will incorporate several strategies ensuring inclusivity and cultural responsiveness:

- **Culturally Responsive Support:** Tutors and mentors will be **trained in equity and diversity awareness**. For example, tutors working with English Language Learners or newcomers will use ESL strategies and be sensitive to cultural differences in learning. Mentors will be recruited to reflect the diversity of the student population – including mentors from various cultural and professional backgrounds – so that students see role models they can identify with. Resources from the Ministry's **Indigenous Education Strategy** and **Inclusive Education** frameworks will inform training content, ensuring that support is adapted for Indigenous students and others who may have unique cultural or linguistic needs. The program could involve local Indigenous educators or elders in areas with high Indigenous student populations, adding a culturally appropriate mentorship dimension and aligning with Truth and Reconciliation education calls to action.

[33] https://efis.fma.csc.gov.on.ca/faab/Memos/B2023/B03_EN.pdf

- **Addressing Special Education Needs:** Students with identified learning disabilities or special education needs will be welcomed in the program, with necessary accommodations in place. Tutors with special education qualifications or experience will be assigned as needed, and tutor training will include effective methods for supporting students with learning exceptionalities (for instance, techniques for ADHD, strategies for students with dyslexia or dyscalculia, etc.). The after-school format may even help some students who need extra time or alternate instructional approaches beyond the regular class period. Coordination with each student's existing Individual Education Plan (IEP) and with their daytime teachers will ensure consistency of support.
- **Language Accessibility:** Ontario's two official languages of instruction (English and French) will both be supported. Francophone schools (and students in French Immersion programs) will have access to French-speaking tutors and mentors, and all program materials will be made available in both English and French. This ensures that French-language school boards and their students benefit equally from the program, in line with Ontario's commitment to supporting education in both official languages[34]. Where there is a significant population of newcomer families, the program can also coordinate with settlement agencies or use multilingual volunteers to facilitate communication with parents in their first language.
- **Monitoring Equity of Access:** The program administrators (both at the provincial and school board level) will monitor enrollment data to ensure the program is reaching the intended populations. This includes tracking demographic information (without compromising privacy) such as the socio-economic indicators of participants, their academic baseline, etc. If certain high-need groups or areas are under-represented in participation, outreach will be adjusted. For example, additional efforts will be made to inform families in low-income communities about the free tutoring opportunity, and to simplify registration processes for those who may face language or technology barriers. The Ministry's emphasis on **strengthening human rights and equity in education**[35] will be reflected by continuously asking: *Who are we not yet reaching, and how can we remove barriers for them?*

By keeping a clear focus on the students who stand to gain the most from these services, the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program will serve as a tool for

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[34] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[35] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

equity. It will help fulfill the Ontario government's commitment that *"all students have the opportunity to succeed regardless of their background or family resources,"* as stated in this proposal's founding principles and aligned with the Ministry's own policies on achieving excellence and equity in education.

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5. Budget and Funding Model

To implement the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program at scale, a dedicated funding allocation will be required. The program is envisioned as a publicly funded initiative with opportunities for cost-sharing and in-kind support from partners. Below is a **proposed annual budget breakdown by major category**, based on an illustrative provincial rollout reaching a substantial number of high-need schools:

Table: Proposed annual budget allocation for the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program (figures illustrative).

Funding Model: The primary source of funding for the program would be the Ontario Ministry of Education's budget. The proposal recommends that the province dedicate a stable annual envelope (approximately $45–50 million per year in this model) to ensure the program's continuity. This could be facilitated through the existing education funding mechanisms:

- A designated **envelope within the Grants for Student Needs (GSN)** or its "Responsive Education Programs (REP)" component (previously known as Priorities and Partnerships Funding) specifically for learning recovery and tutoring/mentoring programs. For context, the Ministry has used PPF/REP grants in the past to fund tutoring initiatives and other equity programs[36] [37].
- Alternatively, a standalone fund administered by the Ministry for after-school programs, which school boards can apply to based on demonstrated need (somewhat analogous to how Special Education or mental health funds are allocated with accountability measures).

School boards receiving the funds would be responsible for deploying them according to the program guidelines – e.g., hiring tutors, paying stipends, purchasing materials – and reporting on spending. It's anticipated that funds would be allocated in proportion

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[36] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

[37] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

to the number of participating students or schools in each board, with weighting for higher-need demographics to ensure equitable distribution.

Cost Efficiency Considerations: The proposed budget is a significant investment, but it should be viewed in context. At roughly $46 million per year, this represents only about **0.16% of Ontario's $28.6 billion K-12 education budget**[38] [39]. The return on investment is expected to be high: tutoring has a strong cost-benefit ratio in terms of learning gained per dollar spent, and early interventions can save costs later by reducing the need for remediation, grade repetition, or social support services when students disengage. The program can also leverage in-kind contributions to effectively increase its resources:

- **Volunteer Hours:** By using community and student volunteers as mentors (and possibly some tutors), the program gains personnel time that isn't fully reflected as salary costs. Volunteers, like university students or community members, provide their time at little to no cost, especially if incentivized by service hours, modest honoraria, or public recognition.
- **Partnership Contributions:** As noted, partnerships with businesses or non-profits can provide free materials, snacks, or even additional funding. For example, the Ministry of Heritage, Sport, Tourism and Culture Industries' *Ontario After School Program* (focused on recreation) operates through grants to local providers and reaches 13,000 youth with a $14.6 million annual budget (approximately)[40] [41]; a similar multi-sector approach can be used here, where some program components (like mental health workshops or recreational activities integrated into the after-school time) are funded through other ministries or sponsors.

Sustainability: The budget above is designed as an annual recurring investment. The Ministry should plan for a multi-year funding horizon (for example, commit funding for an initial 3-year period with an option to extend), allowing school boards to hire staff and set up the program with confidence in its continuity. If the program demonstrates success via improved student outcomes (as anticipated), it can be gradually expanded or made permanent, potentially even scaled up to serve more students or more

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[38] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[39] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[40] https://www.gtaweekly.ca/ontario-after-school-programs-2025/

[41] https://www.gtaweekly.ca/ontario-after-school-programs-2025/

schools. In the long term, stable funding could be built into the provincial education budget, signifying that after-school academic support is a core component of Ontario's public education system, not a one-off initiative.

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6. Evaluation and Metrics for Success

To ensure accountability and demonstrate the impact of the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program, a robust evaluation plan will be put in place. The program's success will be measured using a combination of **quantitative performance metrics** and **qualitative feedback**, aligned with the stated objectives. Key metrics and evaluation strategies include:

Academic Achievement Metrics:

- **Improvement in Literacy and Numeracy Scores:** Track participating students' progress in reading, writing, and math. Baseline data will be collected (e.g., beginning-of-year reading levels, previous report card grades, or prior EQAO scores), and compared with subsequent performance. **Success indicators** might include percentage of participants who move up at least one proficiency level (e.g., from below standard to meeting standard) on EQAO assessments[42], average increase in reading levels for struggling readers, or improvements in classroom test scores. Where available, compare participants' gains to non-participating peers as a control group.
- **Credit Accumulation and Course Pass Rates (Secondary):** For high school students in the program, monitor the rate of successfully earned credits, especially in key courses like Grade 9 and 10 math and English. A goal might be to significantly increase the percentage of at-risk students earning all their credits each term. For example, if only 68% of First Nations students were on track in Grade 9 before[43], the program might aim to raise credit accumulation for participants closer to the provincial average (e.g., into the 80s). Additionally, track any changes in the 4-year and 5-year graduation rates for schools with the program, over a longer term.
- **Standardized Test Results:** Analyze results from the Education Quality and Accountability Office (EQAO) assessments in participating schools before and after program implementation. We expect to see an upward trend in the proportion of students meeting or exceeding provincial standards in reading,

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[42] https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/toronto/eqao-results-2023-1.7335283

[43] https://education.chiefs-of-ontario.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/SystemicGapsProject_StudentOutcomes-1.pdf

writing, and math. Particular attention will be paid to improvements among subgroups (e.g., students from low-income families, racialized students) to see if gaps are closing.

Engagement and Well-Being Metrics:

- **Attendance and Absenteeism:** Given the correlation between engagement and attendance, track the attendance records of participating students during the program period and compare to their previous attendance. A reduction in chronic absenteeism rates for program participants (or in the school overall) would be a positive sign. If mentors are effective, students should be more motivated to attend school regularly. For instance, improving chronically absent students' attendance to above 90% of days in a term could be a target (addressing severe issues like those highlighted for Northern and First Nations students)[44].
- **Student and Parent Surveys:** Conduct surveys or collect feedback from students in the program regarding their self-confidence in academic subjects, attitude toward school, and perceived benefit of the tutoring and mentorship. Similarly, parents can be surveyed about their child's engagement and any changes they observe (e.g., "My child is more interested in reading now" or "My child's math homework is less stressful"). High satisfaction rates and positive testimonials will indicate success on the qualitative front. The mentors and tutors can also be surveyed about their experiences and any noticeable student improvements or remaining challenges.
- **Extracurricular Involvement and Behavior:** While the program's main focus is academic, a well-rounded measure of success includes students' overall school involvement and conduct. Schools can monitor whether participating students show increased participation in class, join more school activities, or have fewer disciplinary issues over time. Improved behavior and engagement often accompany better academic performance and mentorship influence.

Equity and Reach Metrics:

- **Participation Rates of Target Groups:** Evaluate whether the program is reaching the intended populations. Metrics include the number of students served, broken down by demographic categories (e.g., how many low-income, Indigenous, or special education students are participating, compared to their proportion in the school). Ideally, the program should have representation from all targeted groups proportionate to or exceeding their representation in the

[44] https://education.chiefs-of-ontario.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/SystemicGapsProject_StudentOutcomes-1.pdf

struggling-student population. If gaps are found (for example, if English Language Learners are under-enrolled relative to need), adjustments will be made through additional outreach or capacity in those areas.

- **School and Community Impact:** Assess the program's impact at the school level. This could involve comparing outcome metrics between schools that implement the program and demographically similar schools that do not (as a form of control group) to see if the schools with the program show greater improvements in test scores or other indicators. Additionally, measure if the overall school culture and morale improves – possibly via school climate surveys – as an indirect benefit of the program. For community impact, track volunteer engagement (number of mentors/tutors recruited, hours contributed) as a metric of community involvement in education. High volunteer turnout and retention would demonstrate community buy-in and the program's social value.

Monitoring and Reporting:

The Ministry of Education will collect data from boards on these metrics at regular intervals. An annual **Program Outcomes Report** will be compiled, highlighting achievements, challenges, and recommendations. The program will incorporate a continuous improvement model: using data to refine tutor training, adjust session frequency, reallocate resources, or modify targeting as needed. For transparency, key results (e.g., number of students served, average gains in reading levels, etc.) could be shared publicly each year, showing taxpayers the return on their investment in student success.

Furthermore, an independent evaluation may be commissioned after the first 2–3 years (perhaps by a research team or a third-party evaluator) to provide an objective assessment of the program's effectiveness and cost-benefit. This evaluation would inform any decisions on scaling up or modifying the program. If certain elements are found especially effective (for example, if one-on-one tutoring yields significantly better outcomes than small group in a particular subject), the program can be adjusted to incorporate those findings.

By rigorously tracking these metrics, the Ministry and all stakeholders will ensure the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program remains outcomes-focused and truly delivers on its promise to help students **catch up and excel** in their education.

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7. Alignment with Ontario Ministry of Education Priorities

This proposal directly supports and enhances the **strategic priorities of the Ontario Ministry of Education** and the Government of Ontario's commitments to student success, equity, and economic future-readiness. Below are key points of alignment:

- **Foundational Skills in Literacy and Math:** The Ministry has a stated focus on "back-to-basics" education, emphasizing reading, writing, and math proficiency as the bedrock of student success[45]. The After-School Tutoring Program is fundamentally about reinforcing these exact foundational skills. By providing systematic remediation and practice in literacy and numeracy, the program will help students meet the higher curriculum expectations the Ministry has set (e.g. the new early reading mandate and updated math curriculum). The Ministry's **2023–24 education plan** highlighted significant new investments in early reading (e.g., hiring intervention teachers, universal screening in K–Grade 2) and math (e.g., math coaches, digital tools, and expanded online tutoring)[46] [47]. Our proposed program extends these efforts beyond school hours, accelerating progress in the same priority areas and ensuring that daytime lessons are reinforced after school.
- **Learning Recovery Post-COVID:** The Ontario government's **Learning Recovery Action Plan (2022)** was a direct response to pandemic disruptions, launching province-wide tutoring and other measures[48] [49]. Education Minister Stephen Lecce described it as the "**largest provincial investment in tutoring supports**" and a key pillar of helping students catch up[50] [51]. By adopting a permanent After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program, the government would institutionalize and sustain this learning recovery effort. It transitions from one-time emergency funding into a long-term solution embedded in the education system. This aligns with the Ministry's approach of using data and evidence (such as EQAO results and credit accumulation figures) to inform ongoing support for students who

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[45] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[46] https://efis.fma.csc.gov.on.ca/faab/Memos/B2023/B03_EN.pdf

[47] https://efis.fma.csc.gov.on.ca/faab/Memos/B2023/B03_EN.pdf

[48] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

[49] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

[50] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

[51] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

need it[52] [53]. In short, the proposal is a natural next step in the learning recovery journey – moving from short-term catch-up to enduring support.

- **Equity and Closing Gaps:** One of the government's declared priorities is to **ensure equity in education and target supports to where they are needed most**[54]. The Ministry's policies (e.g., the *Education Equity Action Plan* and various equity strategy documents) emphasize closing achievement gaps for marginalized student groups. This program is inherently an equity initiative: it aims to level the playing field by giving extra help to those at risk of being left behind. It also resonates with existing equity programs mentioned in Ministry communications, such as:
    - *Focus on Youth:* which provides opportunities in low-income neighborhoods[55] – our program similarly focuses on low-income and underserved communities, but through academic intervention.
    - *Graduation Coaches for Black Students:* which uses mentorship to support Black youth[56] – our program would broaden this concept to other students in need while complementing such specialized initiatives.
    - *Indigenous Education Strategy:* the Chiefs of Ontario have highlighted the need for better supports to improve First Nations student outcomes[57]. By extending tutoring and mentorship to First Nations students attending provincial schools (and potentially partnering with First Nations communities and organizations for culturally appropriate delivery), the program supports Indigenous learner success in line with Ontario's commitments to reconciliation and Indigenous education.
      In the Ministry's own multi-year strategic plans, it lists as a responsibility the implementation of "programs to support Indigenous education, inclusive education, well-being and parent/community engagement" and "supports for achievement and equitable outcomes for students

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[52] https://efis.fma.csc.gov.on.ca/faab/Memos/B2023/B03_EN.pdf

[53] https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/toronto/eqao-results-2023-1.7335283

[54] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[55] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

[56] https://news.ontario.ca/en/release/1001623/ontario-launches-largest-tutoring-support-program

[57] https://education.chiefs-of-ontario.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/SystemicGapsProject_StudentOutcomes-1.pdf

requiring special education programs"[58]. The proposed program clearly fulfills these mandates by providing direct support to those very students and by engaging community and family in the process.

- **Student Well-Being and Mental Health:** Ontario has significantly increased investment in student mental health and well-being in recent years[59], recognizing that academic success is intertwined with mental health. Mentorship – a key part of our program – is a proven strategy to bolster student well-being and resilience. Having a caring mentor can help alleviate stress, provide guidance, and connect students to resources, aligning with the province's focus on mentally healthy schools. By boosting confidence and reducing academic-related anxiety (for example, a student who overcomes frustration in math through tutoring will feel less anxious and more competent, improving overall well-being), the program supports the **whole-child approach** that the Ministry advocates (as seen in policies integrating well-being into the education agenda).
- **Community Engagement and Partnerships:** The program's reliance on community volunteers and organizations complements the Ministry's push for parent and community engagement in education[60]. It creates structured opportunities for community members to contribute to student success. This reflects a government priority of delivering "better services" by leveraging partnerships and fostering local involvement in schools. In a broader sense, the program prepares today's students for tomorrow by improving their skills, which ties into Ontario's economic priorities (a better-educated workforce). It also gives leadership and teaching experience to the volunteer mentors and tutors, including high school and university students – essentially helping to train the next generation of educators and community leaders, which is a positive side-effect aligning with workforce development goals.
- **Supporting Ministry Accountability Goals:** Under recent legislation (e.g., *Bill 98, the Better Schools and Student Outcomes Act, 2023*), school boards must set student achievement priorities and report progress to the public[61]. A

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[58] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[59] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[60] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[61] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

formal program like this provides a concrete strategy for boards to include in their multi-year plans to boost achievement. The metrics gathered from the program (Section 6) can feed into board and ministry accountability reports, demonstrating a proactive response to identified needs. The program thus becomes a vehicle through which the Ministry and school boards can show measured improvements in outcomes year-over-year, which aligns with the government's drive for transparency and results in education[62].

In essence, the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program is **well-aligned with Ontario's educational priorities**: it reinforces the basics (math and literacy), tackles learning recovery, advances equity, supports well-being, and engages communities. By implementing this program, the Ontario government would be acting consistently with its public commitments to help every student "reach their full potential" and build an education system that is both high-quality and fair for all.

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8. Conclusion

The After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program offers a strategic, evidence-based solution to one of Ontario's most pressing post-pandemic challenges: **helping students who have fallen behind get back on track and thrive.** This proposal has detailed how the program would operate and why it is needed, but its core premise is simple – **investing in our students' success outside of regular school hours will pay dividends inside the classroom and beyond.** By dedicating resources to extra academic help and positive mentorship, the Ontario government can ensure that learning gaps are addressed before they widen, and that all students – regardless of background – have the support needed to achieve provincial standards and graduate with confidence.

This initiative is not a step into the unknown; it builds on lessons learned from recent Ministry programs and community initiatives. We have seen the impact that focused tutoring can have in short-term pilots and the difference that caring mentors make in the lives of youth. The proposal takes those proven approaches to the next level, integrating them into Ontario's public education system in a sustainable way. It is a **proactive investment** that will yield long-term benefits: higher literacy and numeracy rates, a more skilled future workforce, reduced economic inequality, and a generation of students who feel valued and supported.

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[62] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

Recommendation: It is recommended that the Government of Ontario **adopt and fund the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program** as outlined in this proposal, beginning with a multi-year commitment to launch the program in targeted schools by the next academic year. A detailed implementation plan should be developed in collaboration with education stakeholders immediately, so that tutor and mentor recruitment, training development, and resource preparation can begin as soon as possible.

By acting now, Ontario can capitalize on the current momentum for learning recovery and make a clear statement that every student matters. This program will help fulfill the Ministry's mandate to **improve student achievement and ensure equitable education outcomes for all**, turning those important principles into action[63] [64]. The challenges of the pandemic have highlighted where our education system needs bolstering; this proposal presents a path forward. We urge the Ministry of Education to consider this program for implementation. Together, we can provide the **extra support and mentorship that Ontario's students need and deserve**, helping them not only catch up from recent setbacks but soar to new heights of success in the years to come.

Thank you for your consideration of this proposal. We welcome the opportunity to discuss these recommendations further and to assist in any way with the development and realization of the After-School Tutoring and Mentorship Program for Ontario.

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[63] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education

[64] https://www.ontario.ca/page/published-plans-and-annual-reports-2024-2025-ministry-education